DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Does Everything Depend on God's Unity?

Daat Tevunot, Summary

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §42-43, with a summary of §1-43 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Tuesday 22 November 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

The Sekhel sums up (§42)

From this week the shiurim move to Tuesdays and Thursdays. The Rabbi had set homework, to read the summaries in the English edition, and few had done it, so the class went through everything again.

In §42 the Sekhel says the principles are simple. God wanted to reveal His oneness: that nothing can go against His will. On that basis He created the universe. He conceals His face and allows evil to exist until the day He reveals His full goodness, when there will be no more evil and everyone will recognise His unity. Everyone will then see that all the bad in the world, whether done by people or existing in the universe, was orchestrated by Hashem and comes together in the end. Meanwhile, while the deficiencies exist, we have free will. Once yihud Hashem is revealed, that is the time of reward.

The Neshamah's last question (§43)

Before the full summary, the Neshamah asks one final question, which the Rabbi called very strong. At the very beginning of the book you told me that God wanted to give good to His creatures and wanted them to earn it, and that this is why there is good, evil, reward and punishment, and free will. That is enough. Why bring in yihud Hashem at all? Just have good and bad and free choice.

A participant answered that recognising yihud Hashem is the mechanism by which we move from bad to good. The Rabbi called it excellent, and said the Ramhal will show it is also intrinsic to the plan.

The proof: the world ends

The Ramhal's proof: the prophets promise that God's oneness will be revealed and that free choice will one day end forever, with no more sin and no more evil. If the whole purpose were only that people choose good and make it their own, why should that ever end? Let the world go on and on, with people being created, choosing, dying, and receiving their reward in olam haba somewhere else.

A participant suggested that perhaps there are parallel universes doing exactly that. The Rabbi said that is not the Ramhal's point: who knows, and it has nothing to do with us. Another asked about the Midrash that God built and destroyed worlds before this one; the Rabbi said that refers to worlds without human beings, a different matter. The question is why this universe ends at 6,000 years. The answer is that yihud Hashem is pivotal. In the Ramhal's words, "shittef haKadosh Barukh Hu shenei inyanim keehad": God joined two matters together. Giving good through free choice and revealing His unity are intertwined. By refraining from bad and becoming better, we bring yihud Hashem into our lives.

Questions on the end of days

- **Will everyone be redeemed?** Not everyone. The majority will, but someone liable to karet ceases to exist and does not see the revelation.
- **When does Mashiah fit in?** Mashiah must come within the next 217 years and ends at 6,000. If he came today we would have him for 217 years. When the Talmud spoke of Mashiah, just after the Roman exile, two thousand years lay ahead and it was very important. Now, about 1,954 years after the Temple's destruction, and in the big scheme of eternity, Mashiah and tehiyat hametim are minor. What is big is olam haba and yihud Hashem. After 6,000 there is a further thousand years, which is separate, and then eternity. Pressed on this, the Rabbi agreed that we must wait every day, not for Mashiah as such, but for the revelation of yihud Hashem, which Mashiah ushers in.
- **Why 6,000 and then 7,000?** The Rabbi gave an idea in the name of the Maharal. Six is the complete physical world: every three-dimensional thing has six sides. Build a cupboard from six planks and you still need an invisible centre around which it is built; that seventh is spirituality within the physical. Eight is beyond nature altogether, which is why brit milah, on the eighth day, overrides Shabbat, the seventh.

Part one in one paragraph

The Rabbi then read the English edition's summaries, insisting that the Ramhal builds brick on brick, so anyone who has not understood these two parts will struggle with the rest of the book.

The summary of part one: the student struggles with God's direction of the world, reward and punishment, Mashiah and tehiyat hametim, and is content with general principles. Since God is the ultimate good, He wants to give man the greatest good, so He creates him imperfect, with the task of perfecting himself and the world, so that he earns his reward and is not embarrassed by it. Perfection is closeness to God; imperfection is whatever distances us from Him. To make a world of imperfection, God held back His infinite essence.

"Did you see a word about yihud Hashem in that paragraph?" asked the Rabbi. None. That is the first of the two intertwined concepts. Asked what Adam's imperfection was before the sin, he said the very ability to do bad is an imperfection, even if one does not do it.

Part two in six points

1. **Revealing God's oneness is the centre of creation.** God reveals only a small part of His perfection; the one element we can grasp with total clarity is His unity, and all history serves

to let us experience it. We are obliged to make it penetrate our inner being.

2. **The definition of oneness.** Not only that there is one God, but that there is absolutely no power besides His and nothing can oppose His will. This refutes all the false belief systems. History will prove His absolute power, and He will redeem Israel whether they are worthy or not.
3. **The process requires the temporary existence of evil.** To show that nothing has power except Him, evil must exist and then be seen to have no power of its own. His other attributes would not require evil, since they are defined positively. A participant asked how unity can need evil if evil is to be banished. The Rabbi explained that the revelation is the "click moment": something looked like it was not one, and then you see that it was all one. You need an element of darkness to reveal the light at the end.
4. **The revelation requires the destruction of evil.**
5. **It can come in two ways:** through us, or automatically, but either way it must come. Adam had the chance and missed it.
6. **The whole picture:** God chose to reveal His absolute oneness and built the world on that foundation. He concealed His presence to create imperfection and evil, giving man the task of perfecting the world and earning reward. Since evil will be destroyed, the world will be perfected, free choice will end, and man will be rewarded forever for what he achieved while choice existed.

The Rabbi asked everyone to know both summaries "cold" for Thursday, when he would test them before starting a new section.

Summary

- The Sekhel's summary: God built the world to reveal His unity, hiding His face and allowing evil until He reveals Himself fully.
- The Neshamah asks why yihud Hashem is needed if the purpose is simply to earn the good through free choice.
- The proof that it is needed: free choice and this world come to an end, which only makes sense if their goal is the revelation of His unity; the two purposes are intertwined.
- Mashiah ends at 6,000 and is small in the scale of eternity; the great goal is olam haba and the revelation of yihud Hashem.
- Part one explains why evil exists (to earn the good); part two explains what it is for (to reveal God's unity).

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